

How Big Is the AI Bubble? Will an AI Bubble Crisis Far Exceed the 2008 Financial Crisis?

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Discussion of the AI bubble has been heating up of late. Some say the AI bubble is about to burst; others say there is a bubble but no sign of bursting; still others say there is no bubble at all. Those who have read my earlier answers and articles know that I firmly believe an AI bubble exists and that it must burst (my earliest answer on the subject: "Standing at the end of 2025, do you think AI is a genuine revolution or a false boom?").

For several years AI produced nothing much of consequence — so much so that last year a series of institutions poured cold water on it, warning society that AI's real boost to productivity is extremely limited. But as AI coding gradually showed considerable productivity in early 2026 (see: "Do you think AI programming will really replace programmers in the future?"), some people decided AI was promising again and the bubble was gone. I recently watched a video by Victor Gao which on the one hand says the bursting of the AI bubble will trigger a global financial crisis, and on the other says AI is going to replace humanity. The contradiction in such logic is astonishing. If AI truly had the productive capacity to replace people, then what bubble would there be? The very notion of an AI bubble bursting would not exist. But if an AI bubble exists, that can only mean AI is still a hundred thousand miles from replacing human beings — a science-fiction scenario not worth mentioning in serious political-economic discussion.



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In fact, on the basis of current AI applications, we can make a rough estimate of the size of the AI bubble.

Since ChatGPT's release in 2022, the total value of AI-related stocks has reached 10 trillion dollars; with OpenAI and Anthropic heading for IPO, the total market value added could reach 12 trillion. Those are only the biggest firms; other AI-related companies on the US market, whose share prices have risen on the strength of AI, would together push the total past 15 trillion. Adding the share-price

risers of AI-related companies in China, Europe, Japan, and South Korea, the total price of AI-related stocks worldwide can reach 16–17 trillion dollars.

企业名称	股票代码	增值前市值 (约 2022年11月)	当前总市值 (约 2026年)	绝对增加值 (美元)	市值增长 率
英伟达	NVDA	~\$4,100亿	~\$4.85万亿	+\$4.44万亿	+1,084%
微软	MSFT	~\$1.80万亿	~\$2.78万亿	+\$9,800亿	+54%
谷歌母公司 Alphabet	GOOGL	~\$1.15万亿	~\$2.25万亿	+\$1.10万亿	+95%
亚马逊	AMZN	~\$0.90万亿	~\$2.35万亿	+\$1.45万亿	+161%
Meta	META	~\$0.25万亿	~\$1.25万亿	+\$1.00万亿	+400%
苹果	AAPL	~\$2.30万亿	~\$3.15万亿	+\$8,500亿	+37%
甲骨文	ORCL	~\$0.22万亿	~\$0.52万亿	+\$5,000亿	+136%

Image generated by Google Gemini

Some of these firms are model companies, some are application companies, some hardware companies — but all their revenue ultimately comes from the fees paid by the people and enterprises that use AI. So how large, exactly, are the potential profits of the AI applications we can currently see?

Today AI has two clearest uses. The first is an enhanced search engine, serving individuals in their lives or work; when enterprises purchase AI services, they too ultimately turn it into a sort of search engine — a huge database with automatic collation capacity. The second is AI coding.

The global search engine market is roughly 280 billion dollars in size^[1] — 90% of it belongs to Google alone, with a profit margin of about 20%, i.e. 56 billion dollars. Suppose that in the next ten years AI triples the search engine market to 840 billion dollars, with the profit margin unchanged: total profits would then reach 168 billion dollars.

The global software industry's total market size is 823.9 billion dollars, expected to reach 2.45 trillion by 2035^[2]. Generally speaking, in the software industry, labour costs are around 60%^[3]. If AI

replaces 50% of the human labour, AI would bring the software industry 247.2 billion dollars in gains. Of course, these gains cannot all go to the AI industry; the software companies will retain a portion of them, otherwise they would have no incentive to replace people with AI. Suppose the AI companies keep 30% of the gains: the revenue provided to the AI industry is then 173 billion dollars. Suppose the AI industry's own profit margin reaches 50% (basically impossible): the profit is then 86.5 billion dollars. On the estimate that the software industry will reach 2.45 trillion by 2035, by 2035 the AI industry's revenue from the software industry would be 514.4 billion dollars, and its profit 257.2 billion dollars. According to Gartner's report^[4], in 2026 the global software market's total size is 1.25 trillion dollars; calculated on this basis, total profits are 131.3 billion dollars.

In sum: the total profits of today's AI industry can at most reach 56 billion + 86.5 billion = 142.5 billion dollars; or, on Gartner's estimate, 56 billion + 131.3 billion = 187.3 billion. By 2035, the profit ceiling is expected to reach 168 billion + 257.2 billion = 425.2 billion dollars.

Normally the ratio of share price to price-earnings multiple falls in the range of 10–25, meaning that a current AI-related market value of 1.4 to 3.6 trillion dollars is normal (by Gartner's figures, 1.8 to 4.7 trillion). On the basis of 2035 forward earnings, the normal range for AI-related market value is 4.3 to 10.6 trillion dollars.

As counted above, the total value of AI-related stocks has already reached the scale of 17 trillion dollars — far exceeding AI's entire current profit space, even greater than AI's total profit space in 2035. Judged by the normal share prices inferred from the current profit ceiling, the global AI bubble is around 13–15 trillion dollars. But share prices are about the future; one cannot consider only the present. Even so, the equipment in AI data centres depreciates in 3–5 years and will not last until 2035; we may take the midpoint between now and 2035, roughly 3.1 to 7.1 trillion. Even on this calculation the global AI bubble is on the scale of 10 to 14 trillion. By any estimate, the AI bubble is on the order of 10 trillion dollars.

At the time of the 2000 internet bubble, the total market value involved in the bubble's collapse was about 6 trillion dollars — roughly 11.6 trillion in today's money. The bubble of the 2008 subprime crisis was about 16 trillion, roughly 25 trillion today. The AI bubble is therefore comparable to the internet bubble or somewhat larger, and far smaller than the bubble that preceded the 2008 financial crisis. We may conclude that Victor Gao's claim — that the AI bubble crisis is ten times the internet crisis and far exceeds 2008 — is inaccurate; the impact of this bubble's bursting will indeed lie between the internet bubble crisis and the subprime crisis.

PS: To pre-empt the AI-apocalypse and humanoid-robot-invincibility theories, may I point interested friends to my earlier articles:

"Much of the Imagination About AI and Robots Is Unrealistic"

"After the Spring Festival Gala the robots sold out — Unitree's Gala robots cost 200,000 yuan; what can they actually do off stage? Can this wave of hype launch the sector?"

"How should we view Microsoft's AI chief's prediction that 'within the next 18 months, most white-collar jobs will be completely replaced by AI'?"

Notes

[1] Global Search Engine Market size was valued at USD 223.41 Billion in 2024, poised to grow between USD 245.75 Billion in 2025 to USD 526.79 Billion by 2033, growing at a CAGR of 10% in the forecast period.

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<https://www.skyquestt.com/report/search-engine-market>

[2] Why the Software Market is a High-Growth Investment Opportunity Through 2035 | Market to Surpass USD 2.47 Trillion

中文原文： Why the Software Market is a High-Growth Investment Opportunity Through 2035 | Market to Surpass USD 2.47 Trillion

<https://finance.yahoo.com/news/why-software-market-high-growth-114000893.html>

[3] Direct Cost Breakdown: Labour: 50–60% of total cost; Technology Stack: 20–30%; Third-Party Services: 10–15%; Hardware: 5–10%

中文原文： Direct Cost Breakdown Labour: 50-60% of total cost Technology Stack: 20-30% of total cost Third-Party Services: 10-15% of total cost Hardware: 5-10% of total cost

<https://www.softwaredevelopment.co.uk/blog/software-development-costs/>

[4] Gartner forecasts worldwide IT spending to grow 10.8% in 2026, totaling 6.15 trillion dollars

<https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2026-02-03-gartner-forecasts-worldwide-it-spending-to-grow-10-point-8-percent-in-2026-totaling-6-point-15-trillion-dollars>

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